

# AM 7 Job Aid. Check Into A Radio Net

Guidance for checking into a Radio Net.

## General Instructions

The net is defined in Army MARS publication AM-6. The time period of the net is 24 hours each day and is free-net for most hours. Directed net activity may only occur at certain scheduled hours.

Directed Net activity is controlled by the Net Control Station (NCS). Stations checking into a directed net should use concise language, minimize the amount of other people's time they consume and follow the instructions of the NCS.

A Free Net runs over a long periods of time and there may not be a NCS. Those stations not assigned to guard the net can come and go as they please. Check in is not required and radio calls can be made without going through the NCS

This job-aid contains examples of radio calls made between the calling station and the Net Control Station. Noted in these examples is the ACP-125\* schematic's format lines. These lines are for reference and not verbalized.

## 1. Net Call Up

The Net Control Station (NCS) will make a NET CALL on the optimum calling frequency assigned for the time of day, season, 11 year cycle and desired area of operation. Radio frequencies are listed on NETPLAN Table D-1, COMMS CARD and is selected at the discretion of the NCS based on the existing conditions. It is your responsibility to scan through the most likely calling frequencies for the time of day, and locate the net.

The NET CALL is a call to all stations in the net. The NCS will use the phrase "All Stations This Net" to call the net, use more specific language to select certain stations. The NCS may also append the Net Call with instructions. Examples of Net Calls:

(fl2) **ALL STATIONS THIS NET,**  
(fl3) **THIS IS (NCS Call Sign)**  
(fl4) **THIS IS A DIRECTED NET**  
(fl16) **OVER**

(fl2) **STATIONS WITH TRAFFIC,**  
(fl3) **THIS IS (NCS Call Sign)**  
(fl4) **THIS IS A DIRECTED NET**  
(fl16) **OVER**

*These examples include the ACP-125\* procedure format line for reference. Format lines are not verbalized.*

## 2. Answer The Net Call

To check into the net after the NCS makes a net call for stations that matches your station, transmit an abbreviated call using your full call sign\*\*. If your station holds traffic for the net, this is the time to declare it by stating the precedence of the traffic. State the number of messages only if the number is greater than one. If your station does not hold traffic, pause a few seconds to let the stations with traffic to be heard first. Examples:

(fl3) **THIS IS (YOUR FULL CALL SIGN)**  
(fl16) **OVER**

(fl3) **THIS IS (YOUR FULL CALL SIGN)**  
(fl5) **PRIORITY**  
(fl16) **OVER**

The NCS will answer your call along with the call signs of other stations that called in to the net. Expect the NCS to take stations with traffic first. Pay attention for your abbreviated call sign to ensure you have been checked in.

When check in is complete, the NCS will also transmit the net roster. This roster establishes the order in which stations respond to a net call. Write this roster in your radio log, note the stations you can hear and the traffic they listed, and make a mental note of the station you follow in the roster.

- **Do not** pause at any time when making a call. Make your calls quick and succinct.
- Once communications is established with the net, use Abbreviated Call Signs. No special permission or direction is required or desired to start using abbreviated call signs.

Refer to ACP-125\* for authentication and challenge procedure if required.

## 2A. Checking in Late or Returning to the Net.

If you are checking into the net late, or back into the net after leaving, initiate a call to the NCS at any time following the proword “OUT” and before any other station makes a call. Make a full call that includes the NCS call sign. Example:

(fl2) **(NCS CALL SIGN)**  
(fl3) **THIS IS (YOUR FULL CALL SIGN)**  
(fl16) **OVER**

The NCS will tell you which station you follow in the net roster. If you check in late, the NCS generally will not send you the net roster.

## 3. Sending Traffic

Unless the traffic is for everyone on the net, the NCS will not allow it to be sent on the main frequency during the direct net. This is to allow the net to conclude as quickly as possible. You may:

- Send the traffic after the directed net concludes. In this case, when the NCS calls you for your traffic, simply tell the NCS the call sign of the station for which you are holding traffic and request that station remain until free net for traffic. This is the best choice when time of delivery is not critical and the nature of the traffic is personal or administrative.
- Send the traffic on a “Working” (Alternate) frequency. This is a frequency from the discrete frequency list that you selected prior to the net, or the NCS is using to route traffic to a designated station. When selecting a frequency, pick a frequency that is likely to propagate between your station and the station you will send the traffic and check to see if it is clear. This is the preferred method to quickly move the traffic while a directed net is in progress. When the NCS calls your station, request the other station move to the frequency you selected for traffic or move to the frequency the NCS is using, depending on the circumstances.
- Link with the other station using ALE.

## 4. Communications with another station during the net

If you need to communicate with another station during a directed net, contact the NCS and request to make contact with the other station. The same concepts that apply to sending traffic apply to

communications with another station - that is, you should move to a working frequency or link with ALE. Example:

(fl2) **(NCS CALL SIGN)**  
(fl3) **THIS IS (YOUR CALL SIGN)**  
(fl12) **REQUEST COMMS WITH (OTHER STATION CALL SIGN)**  
(fl16) **OVER**

The NCS will tell you to call your station. Make your call and direct that station to change frequency.

(fl2) **(OTHER STATION CALL SIGN)**  
(fl3) **THIS IS (YOUR CALL SIGN),**  
(fl4) **QSY TO (FREQUENCY DESIGNATOR)**  
(fl16) **OVER**

## 5. Polling The Net For Information

The NCS may poll each station in the net for information. This is your opportunity to state relevant information about the operation of the net - such as signal reports, etc.

*Polling the net for information is the procedure used to establish an expanding situational awareness within MARS of a wide area denial of telecommunications services. In this environment it is information provided by other MARS members that establishes awareness, and differentiates between a condition that affects only a local area or a national crisis.*

Radio nets are official business related to the operational task at hand. Observe good OPSEC and use encrypted data to cover information that when aggregated may be sensitive. Do not discuss any matter that can be used to assess the readiness and capabilities of MARS or US forces, which includes admitting to frustration or confusion. Remain emotionally neutral when facing adversity. Keep in mind others are standing by and their time is valuable. Human resource and other administrative matters are best handled by telephone or email. Technical support can be provided through the telephone bridge.

Personal opinion and remarks are not appropriate. It is not appropriate to provide "comments" during this time.

## 6. Free Net

If the NCS has stated "THIS IS A FREE NET" you may call another station directly without the NCS. You may also leave the net or close your station at your discretion, without requesting permission.

## 7. Closing Station or Leaving the Net

If you must leave the net early, you must call the NCS and request permission to either “Leave The Net”, or “Close Down”. “Leave The Net” implies that your station will continue to operate but not in this particular net, whereas “Close Down” means you are turning off your station equipment.

Examples:

(fl2) **(NCS CALL SIGN)**  
(fl3) **THIS IS (YOUR CALL SIGN)**  
(fl12) **REQUEST TO LEAVE THE NET**  
(fl16) **OVER**

(fl2) **(NCS CALL SIGN)**  
(fl3) **THIS IS (YOUR CALL SIGN)**  
(fl12) **REQUEST CLOSE DOWN**  
(fl16) **OVER**

*\* Note on conformity with ACP125. The Allied Communications Protocol (ACP) 125 is the standard for voice communications for US and Allied forces. It is a collection and colleague of each stakeholder’s best practices and experiences which establishes the guidance for radio telephone procedure. Some parts of ACP125 are held to strictly, such as the order of the called and calling stations in a radio call, or the phonetic alphabet, others parts of the procedure are adapted operationally as required. This are many variations of how ACP125 is adapted in practice, yet they all conform to the standard. A broad interpretation that in intuitive and reduces training burden by minimizing procedural facts is desired. Radio Telephone procedures described here follow current US Army practice, further adopted for MARS, and are the result of evolution over the last two decades of continuous conflict alongside coalition and allied forces.*

*\*\* Note on use of full and abbreviated call signs. Normally, the full call-sign is used when a station first identifies itself to a net, so that the net knows who the station is specifically and can distinguish it from all other radio stations. Once that is established, abbreviated call signs are used afterwards. In some cases, such as special teams of MARS stations, the stations in the net are already known to each other and abbreviated call signs are used exclusively. When operating on Army MARS frequencies, it is assumed the prefix of AAR unless otherwise established by first using a full call sign. While this procedure specifies the practice of first using a full call-sign, it is not meant to prohibit the exclusive use of abbreviated call-signs inside defined teams when it is appropriate and unlikely to cause mis-identification, or prohibit AAR prefix stations from using abbreviated call signs exclusively when operating on Army MARS frequencies.*